

Music

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Grade boundaries

Higher level overall

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 10	11 - 21	22 - 37	38 - 51	52 - 66	67 - 80	81 - 100

Standard level overall

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 10	11 - 20	21 - 36	37 - 50	51 - 63	64 - 76	77 - 100

Exploring music in context

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 2	3 - 4	5 - 7	8 - 10	11 - 13	14 - 16	17 - 24

Experimenting with music

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 2	3 - 4	5 - 10	11 - 14	15 - 17	18 - 21	22 - 28

Higher level the contemporary music maker

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 3	4 - 7	8 - 12	13 - 17	18 - 23	24 - 28	29 - 32

Presenting music

Grade:	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Mark range:	0 - 5	6 - 10	11 - 16	17 - 21	22 - 27	28 - 32	33 - 38

Exploring music in context

The range and suitability of the work submitted

While in the past year, it could be argued that some of the range and suitability of the work submitted had been impacted by Covid and the novelty of the curriculum, these two arguments are less convincing this year. The number of schools and their candidates that continue to misunderstand the requirements is still very high if not higher. This is especially true in the practical exercises (sections 2 and 3). Some of the exercises presented for the adaptation were not musically speaking at the level of someone at the end of a two-year Diploma Programme course or about to enter college.

Candidate performance against each criterion

As in every session, there were some compelling reports. However, this section will focus on describing areas that need attention from schools and candidates. In the section “Recommendation for the supervision of future candidates” there will be a brief analysis of those cases where candidates reached high marks to be used as examples for subsequent sessions.

Criterion A

The number of candidates not reporting areas of inquiry (AOIs) or contexts is still very high. Many candidates do not justify their selections or present arguments that are not convincing. For instance, stating that a waltz by Chopin is AOI-3 because it was used for dancing. This simply demonstrates a lack of exploration (research) because the candidate is not aware that these waltzes were made to listen (AOI-2) and not to be danced (AOI-3). Another very common case is to argue that a piece is AOI-3 (film music) because it was used in a film even if it was composed by Bach or Beethoven. In these cases, candidates do not understand that Bach or Beethoven composed their music without any purpose to support any given film scene.

Candidates are starting to use more timestamps. However, many provide the timestamps that correspond to a YouTube file or a recording used, in their analysis. Since these musical extracts are not included in the submissions, these timestamps are ineffective as evidence. If a candidate is going to use timestamps they need to correspond to the audio evidence provided in upload 3.

Something very common is reports pointing towards a piece with a specific AOI but an analysis that does not explore the specific link between the piece and the AOI or at least specific conventions of the style. Often candidates limit themselves to indicating tempo, key, meter, and dynamics. However, in many cases, these elements are not relevant in a specific piece or do not relate to the argued AOI. They might not even be actual conventions of the styles. Candidates need to be made aware that the characteristics of a piece are not necessarily its conventions.

Some candidates presented notated examples that were not specifically representing anything but were used more as decoration. For instance, the front page of the composition without any specific analysis.

In many cases, candidates provided timestamps as audio evidence. However, these were timestamps of the original recording and not those of upload 3. Therefore, the examiner has no opportunity to verify this evidence.

Criterion B1

In general, research is superficial. One of the goals of this task is that the exploration discovers conventions and performance practices. However, this cannot be achieved with a limited exploration of unreliable sources and/or of one or a few musical examples. Many candidates limit their research to the first site found on the internet. In other cases, they focus on general aspects and not on those aspects of the compositions that determine their AOI. For instance, a candidate selects a dance as AOI-3 but does not explore what in the music supports the dance. In the area of film music, candidates seem to be more alert to the relationship between scene action and the accompanying music.

Criterion B2

The overall intention of this component is that candidates produce practical exercises as a result. However, this link is not always existent. In many cases, candidates use as a stimulus for the practical exercises pieces not explored in section 1.

Criterion C1

The focus of this criterion is conventions, not characteristics. A concerto is written in F major does not mean that all concertos are written in F major. The key here is simply a characteristic of this specific concerto. A convention of a concerto would be the alternation between solo and tutti. The Beatles using a sitar in Norwegian Wood is not a convention of the style (rock music). It is simply a characteristic of that specific song. This type of error comes from a limited exploration and understanding of the style. The task here asks the candidate to demonstrate their understanding of conventions. Therefore, an exercise that focuses on simple characteristics will not achieve well against the assessment criterion requirements.

Criterion C2

A similar comment to that of conventions/characteristics could be made about this criterion. Here candidates seem to be focused on transcribing the piece to their instrument. This is not the task. The task is to demonstrate the understanding of a performance practice explored and analyzed. For instance, a performance practice of jazz music is to 'swing' the rhythms. Performance practice in baroque music is to add ornamentation, a performance practice from Höömii music (Mongolian traditional music) is to sing with throat singing. Candidates are asked to play the stimulus on their instruments and to explore how the idiomatic capabilities of their instruments would permit them to apply such performance practices that would not normally be part of the technique of their instruments in their culture. The vast majority of submissions present only a straight transcription of the notes and rhythm of the stimulus without discussing what the performance practices are and without even attempting them as performers. In other cases, candidates attempt to arrange the stimulus in another style. For instance, taking a Flamenco stimulus and arranging it in the jazz style.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future candidates

Candidates must review the Music guide and its requirements with their teachers. An abundant number of candidates make errors such as only exploring one AOI, producing the adaptation from a 'personal context', basing the 'creation' and 'adaptation' from the same AOI, not stating AOI and contexts, and not including in-text references.

Please remind candidates that this component should be presented as a whole. The exploration made informs the creation and the adaptation. These are not independent and isolated areas, but they are interconnected.

Experimenting with music

The range and suitability of the work submitted

Most examiners found a wide variety of work with some noticing a slight improvement on the previous year. Work meeting the criteria at the top end is still less common. In general, most work was between the recreating and adapting mark bands, with successful transformations less present.

Many of the lowest scorers were projects that were poorly conceived or did not conform to the requirements of the component.

Areas of inquiry (AOIs) 2 and 4 were the most common. AOIs 1 and 3 were seen less frequently. AOI3 was most commonly cited for film music, or sometimes for video game music, although this was generally classified under AOI4. AOI3 was sometimes chosen because the music itself was “dramatic” rather than being music for a dramatic production.

Identification of contexts was less present, and their justification, when offered, was often vague.

There were few occasions when the identification of AOI or context was taken further into the commentary.

Far too many responses failed to include an AOI or context(s) and a lot of candidates mentioned personal context, which is not a part of this component.

Creating experimentation is beginning to take form, and schools are starting to have some understanding of what is required, whereas experimenting in performing remains something of a problem when it comes to choosing a project.

Many candidates focused more on creating than performing, and in general commentaries for creating were longer than those for performing.

A number of candidates approached both sections as creating rather than performing, and performing experiments were often just straight performances, with transformation being particularly difficult to achieve.

Candidate performance against each criterion

Rationales that stated clearly the reasons for doing the experimenting were rare. Most rationales were a general statement of intent without much explanation or justification.

Research came in three levels: those who made no reference to any research, those who listed some sources but made little or no reference to them (these were the majority), and those who did some research and, in some way, applied this to the process. Clear reference to research and findings was a weak point.

Criterion A

Candidates receiving the higher marks for criterion A were generally those who set out with a clear project to develop a stimulus, following inspiration taken from other sources, and using creating techniques to achieve this. Lower scorers, often with little or no actual musical knowledge relied on manipulation of playback (changing tempo or key) in order to achieve some change, without having any effective understanding of what they were doing.

Experimenting with technology and experimenting with conventional creating techniques were equally common.

More detail and reference to the elements of music would have helped here.

Some candidates referenced very few sources and their bibliographies only included audio/YouTube tracks.

Many made use of scores, including midi versions, from sites like Muse Score, often not crediting them and then completing simple 'arrangements' which just changed the instrumentation. These generally do not score well.

Criterion B

Most candidates seem to have understood the need to develop musical ideas from source material. Candidates receiving lower marks failed to achieve any effective development, sometimes setting out just to recreate something. Higher scorers made effective use of techniques to create new contexts for ideas and even achieve transformation into new material that still related to the source.

Candidates who chose to compose freely in a style usually only achieved the recreating mark band, as evidence of adaptation of actual musical ideas was difficult to recognize. Some candidates did however achieve the higher mark bands even though not starting out from a specific stimulus. This was usually due to a strong second bullet point rewarding “informed musical decision-making”.

Candidates who submitted three disconnected creating samples scored less well than those submitting a purposeful series of creating experiments.

Criterion C

Candidates receiving the higher marks for performance experimentation were usually those who concentrated on the performing aspects (instrumental or music technology techniques) and applied these different techniques to source material in a logical, experimental way, giving critical evaluation along the way. It was however clear that many candidates were not used to experimenting on their instruments and were more comfortable with simple reiteration. Overall, performing experimentation is still scoring lower than creating, with the higher mark bands – adapting and transforming, proving more difficult to reach.

Some candidates failed to score well in their performing experimenting because the project was more concerned with creating: rewriting the music and then performing it in the new version.

Justifications for the experimenting were often not given or explained - singers fared better here whilst instrumentalists often found it difficult to come up with ideas that were not closer to creating rather than performing: reharmonizing, producing a piece in a completely different style, reworking accompaniments, as examples.

Candidates were often performing pieces they were interested in without clear rationale or supporting evidence.

Criterion D

Candidates achieving higher marks for criterion D managed, through performance, to show development of musical ideas using manipulation in performance of musical elements and the use of different modes of interpretation. Lower scorers offered performances that showed little or no development of the stimulus.

There were occasions when audio evidence for experimenting in performing did not always adequately support the project, that is: the performing capacity of the candidate was not up to making the experimenting audibly effective.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future candidates

It should be remembered that personal context is not applicable in this component. It is generally safer in creating experiments to start out from a clearly defined stimulus piece rather than just to be inspired by an artist or genre. In performing experiments, the candidate should show the desire to change a stimulus through performing in a different way. This does not have to be a new, or unconventional way, just a different way that will bring about some change. Think carefully about the different performance techniques that you could use and experiment with. Critical evaluation need not be copious but is helpful to the commentary and will be noticed by the examiner.

Encourage confident use of the elements of music in describing experimentation processes, using terminology to show understanding.

Ensure differentiation between the approach to creating and performing.

Teachers and candidates should ensure that all primary source material is clearly evidenced and that the nature of each experiment is made clear.

Include reflective/evaluative commentary about each experiment.

Experimenting with performance needs a lot more guidance and instruction - particularly for instrumentalists.

Further comments

Candidates should be encouraged to engage with and familiar with applying the assessment criteria to their work.

Schools need to take time to explain the conceptual framework of the course, the why of the concepts of areas of inquiry and contexts.

Higher level the contemporary music maker

The range and suitability of the work submitted

The May 2023 first assessment session for this component revealed a wide range of submitted work. However, the suitability of the selected work was not very effective from this first cohort. Few of the samples focused on music, lacking in-depth discussions and evidence. The strength of these submissions lay in project planning.

The majority (over 80%) of the submissions were compositions, but many of them lacked control and development of material, especially for candidates at HL.

Many candidates missed the opportunity to utilize supporting documents to expand upon their submitted information. Instead, they often provided transcriptions of their presentation or a synthesis of it. However, there were some good examples where candidates submitted the full score of a composition.

While collaboration was generally understood as an important aspect of the component, many candidates struggled to demonstrate and prove leadership in their identified roles, as stated in the Music guide.

There was also a discrepancy between the Music guide and the submissions regarding the aspect of an identified role. The guide consistently referred to it as a singular "role," but many candidates referred to it in the plural form, such as "my roles have been singer and composer."

Candidate performance against each criterion

Criterion A

Most of the evidence focused on planning and was presented in the form of a PowerPoint presentation with voice-over.

Only a few candidates achieved full marks, showcasing both musical and research evidence.

Some candidates took a very effective approach by including score excerpts and videos of their practice or rehearsals. However, in many cases, there was no evidence of collaboration beyond the candidate's voice discussing it during the presentation.

Criterion B

This criterion proved to be the most challenging. There were only a few examples where candidates effectively discussed the entire process necessary to achieve full marks.

Many candidates spent a significant amount of time discussing planning and did not have enough space to delve into the process in relation to the stated aims.

It was difficult to find examples in the top mark band where candidates discussed the challenges and successes, examined areas for development and improvement, and evaluated their musical and collaborative choices.

Most of the time, this criterion was assessed using a best fit approach.

Criterion C

When candidates followed the submission requirements properly, this criterion was straightforward to mark, and we found some very good pieces. However, issues arose when it was difficult or impossible to

identify the candidate submitting the work. These scenarios included difficulties in identifying a candidate's own work or performance in cases of collaboration.

While sharing the composition process can be interesting, most examples assessed in this session focused on a simple melody with basic chord progressions. Good examples of collaboration involved a candidate composing while another candidate handled production tasks such as recording, editing, mixing, and mastering.

We also encountered cases where candidates were not clearly identified in the presentation, making it challenging to evaluate their individual contributions. Additionally, some candidates took on non-musical roles, such as organizing a concert, without focusing on musical intentions. However, if the same candidate was one of the musicians and provided evidence and discussion of their performance process, technical proficiency could be assessed more easily.

Many submissions included film scores or compositions for art exhibitions, but there were few examples of well-edited scores, with most compositions lacking any score at all.

Criterion D

This criterion was straightforward to mark as presentations were generally purposeful.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future candidates

Teachers and candidates should carefully read and contrast both the learning and teaching and the assessment sections of this component in the Music guide and in particular the submission requirements.

It is crucial to plan activities with the assessment criteria in mind, especially criterion B.

Clear identification of the candidate submitting the work should be emphasized, such as by including a picture or video of the candidate and ensuring they discuss their own contributions.

Submitting original material when working with arrangements is essential; many submissions in this category lacked the original material necessary to assess the candidate's arrangement skills.

In cases of collaboration where candidates share the composition process of the same piece, the clear leadership role should be established for each candidate's individual presentation, and the music presented should be developed in depth to demonstrate excellent technical proficiency.

Candidates should be encouraged to effectively use supporting documents to enhance their presentations. Including as much variety as possible in facilitating the final multimedia presentation is encouraged, candidates should be discouraged from relying solely on speaking over a PowerPoint presentation.

Further comments

This component should be viewed as a whole, encompassing the roles of researcher, performer, and creator. The identified music role should align with the project itself.

Some candidates did not receive marks according to their apparent effort because they were not following the submission requirements and much of that effort was not considered in the assessment process. Therefore, teachers and candidates are strongly encouraged to review the Music guide in more detail, ensuring that they understand the intent of the assessment criteria and that they are applied appropriately in an internal assessment process.

The guide provides clear instructions, but there are still some missed details that require elaboration or reminders. These include stating the one role being assessed, working with a collaborator excluding adults/teachers/professionals, keeping presentations within the 15-minute time limit, and ensuring the final product is presented.

Presenting music

The range and suitability of the work submitted

Not all candidates linked the areas of inquiry (AOI) as well as they should or could, in order to receive marks from the higher mark bands in this component. Candidates and teachers by now, do seem to have understood that all AOI must be addressed in the programme notes and in other areas, but for better marks in area A, clearer 'why' or 'how' / links are still necessary. In view of this, some of the submissions were not ideal and were limited to scoring lower marks.

Candidates are still engaging in first person discourse that has a personal and inappropriate tone to it.

As last session, there were few candidates from ethno-musicological or world music disciplines. Also, there were a number of candidates who relied on rather unstructured 'spontaneous' extemporisations, who often supplied no proper scores, just screen shots. Technically this is allowable, but it is not as effective as planned submissions (where this application is appropriate).

Some candidates undoubtedly engage in misconduct with recordings. Edited submissions, sometimes with clicks and clunks were in evidence at times. Such misconduct is very obvious to examiners and these are always reported as an academic integrity issue. The consequences for the candidate as a result may be serious and teachers are urged to guard against it, by supervising at all times.

Candidate performance against each criterion

Criterion A

The wording of the November 2022 subject report stands for the May 2023 examination session for this component: few candidates scored fewer than 3 or 4 here. However, equally few scored 6. For a really good mark, candidates MUST include scores—they need not be traditional manuscripts—that are relevant. They also must LINK their areas of inquiry (AOI) observations to the music. Like this (purely invented) example:

'This work by J.S. Bach is sacred music, that is to say it was written for real use in Church. It therefore fulfils the object of AOI-1. It does this by quoting ancient choral tunes in its melody (see manuscript extract fig 1), also by setting the sacred text of.....(see fig 2), as well as being specifically written for.....when the composer was.....The work can also be performed in a secular context, but the primary reason for its existence is as sacred repertory, hence AOI-1'

Many candidates engaged in pointless personal reminiscences and personal points. Occasionally such writing might be appropriate, but the word count is far better used in describing the music and how it links to the AOI. Writing in the third person present or past tense (as appropriate) will often discourage personal reminiscences and produce the style needed here.

Here is a (purely invented) example of the sort of writing that does not belong here, but which is encountered regularly enough:

"Last Christmas my cat died. He had meant so much to me that I thought I would try to write some music to get over the loss of losing Benny the cat. He had meant so much to the family and I had had him since he was only a kitten. I thought of all the things he used to do, like playing and running and sitting on my bed at night. So I wrote some music that suggested those things"

Instead, a description of the music and how it links to the AOI, with features in the music that describes this, is needed here, rather than the personal story.

Perhaps:

"My piece is suggestive of the life of a cat. Note how the fast semi-quavers could be suggestive of the fast running; that the contrasting long sustained chords, that move only a little, suggestive of the times when the cat is sleeping. Also, that the title of the piece.....and other features such as.....and.....show how the cat is loved in a family home. It fits into AOI- ? Because it contains.....etc ""

Candidates would be very well advised to remember the following for good marks in A:

1. Write in an academic way, about the music, not about personal reminiscences that do not link to the AOI.
2. Consider writing in the third person, in order to assist this.
3. Concentrate on musical detail and make sure you give links – such as explain WHY and HOW the music fits into each AOI.
4. Label your AOI.
5. Include scores to demonstrate planning and preparation of your creations. Screen shots alone do not always go very far.

Criterion B

Candidates should avoid repetition (unless it is appropriate—in minimalist music, for example), and try to include/develop structure. Often candidates get a very good idea or motif, and present that, but it may not develop.

Some candidates submit music that is played by a computer, but some of this music is, really, only realistically, playable by a computer. In other words, it is so 'unlikely' that it could not with any sort of facility be delivered by real musicians. The best submissions are those that could (even if they are not) be delivered by real ensembles. For example, avoid awkward, angular, unlikely leaps or absurdly fast, impossible patterns, that a computer can play, but a human could not. One submission contained a contrary motion scale up to a tenth for a solo violin – this sort of writing is highly unlikely in the real world.

Criterion C

The playing was not as strong as the November session, an unusual pattern opposite to examiner experience for more than twenty years.

There were problems with accompaniments: music that should be accompanied such as concerto movements, violin sonatas, MUST be properly accompanied. Backing tracks are acceptable, as is computer accompaniment, but, as all musicians will know, they are not ideal. In some cases such generated

accompaniments are very seriously problematic and schools would be wise not to advise their candidates to play to such accompaniments.

Music technology presentations continue to show the candidate. Only a closeup of the equipment and relevant sections of the hardware on the video are required.

Some candidates choose to submit evidence of large ensembles, such as choirs, or big wind ensembles. This is allowable according to the letter of the guide, but when candidates do this, they risk limiting (sometimes seriously) the amount of music making that is available to the examiner to hear with detail. The extractions are quite dry and short. Candidates should think carefully before consigning an entire programme to such repertoire. In order to be heard an ensemble, such as a quartet where candidates play one to a part are far more appropriate in assessment than second alto in a hundred strong choral society, singing in 6 parts with a huge accompaniment.

Criterion D

As in the previous session, generally good. Many candidates scored 5 or 6. Remember that scores can be marked here too. Audio quality, general musical communication (rubato, dynamics, tempo choice) and musical intentions- this is how effective the AOI are followed and transmitted as a whole – are included in this criterion.

Recommendations and guidance for the teaching of future candidates

These are the same as the November session, just past. However, there is an important additional point of caution in relation to large ensembles:

- Consult the Music guide for correct details.
- Write in the third person in A and do not include irrelevant personal stories.
- LINK the writing in A to the musical features in the repertoire selected and submitted.
- Try to introduce structure in B and do not rely on repetition too much.
- Choose repertoire that can be delivered accurately and well—even if simpler than other repertoire that can be delivered but with problems.
- In C do not be tempted to engage in cutting / splicing in other sections of recordings, second takes, or even commercial recordings. This is academic misconduct and is easily detected, is always reported, and can result in very profound consequences.
- Think carefully before delivering an extensive programme that contains huge ensembles. It is possible that the examiner may not be able to have much, or any, repertoire to listen to where the one candidate is identified. This is a personal call for the candidate and their teacher.